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The language of secrecy

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One of the *koli*, Zoman of Sucronsu *taa*, is the patrilineage from which the Poro Zo hierarchy are recruited. Its members claim to have come from Guinea and to be one family (*kala tano*) with the Poro Zo quarters in other towns throughout the district, whether they be Kpelle or Loma. They do not always recognize kinship with Poro Zo from more distant groups, however, even speakers of other Kpelle dialects. One segment of Zo live outside of Zoman *koli* in Yamii *koli*, the patrilocal compound where the Poro fence is located. This quarter, like all the others in town, is divided into subquarters. Yamii is divided first into a lower and an upper half, as the *koli* sits on a small hill. It is in this lower part, in an area named after a famous and powerful Zo ancestor, Bobo, that the Zo reside. Residents of this subquarter refer to the area as Bobo *koli*. They consider themselves to be the *maling*, or sister's child, of the other Yamii subquarter residents. One of the other subquarters also is a Zo family related to Bobo in the *ngala-maling* relationship. They refer to their subquarter by the name of their quarter chief, Kpokawlaw, who is a major Poro Zo. He is responsible for maintaining the outside gate to the Poro fence that surrounds the Zo house where internal Poro discussions and palavers are held. Because the *maling* is expected to show deference to the *ngala*, the other Poro Zo always pay him formal respect, and all Poro matters are "reached" to him before entering into a palaver or engaging in ritual activity.³

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Thus there are two ways of reckoning the *ngala-maling* relationship: (1) that defined by actual descent and (2) the symbolic relationship of the different patrilocal quarters and moieties to each other. In either case, the *maling* is expected to show deference to the *ngala*. This is expressed through a number of formal rights and obligations that each has toward the other. During rituals and sacrifices, these rights and duties are especially important. For example,

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whenever a cow is sacrificed, the *ngala* is given the head and the *maling* the tail.⁴ Also, during the Poro initiations, the *maling* always presents his initiated sons to the *ngala* for approval both before they enter the initiation fence and after they are returned to the community after their period of seclusion. The *maling* of the Zo, the *kwelebah*, is one of the most important non-Zo offices in the society and is especially active during the initiation-ritual process.

Besides the serious or formal rights and obligations between *ngala* and *maling*, other aspects of the relationship are expressed as joking behavior between kinsmen. When drinking palm wine, the *maling* is "to take off 23 the dirt" by taking the first drink, whereas the *ngala* gets the last dregs from the bottom of the gourd; the *maling* is permitted to take any of the *ngala*'s clothes without asking, while the *ngala* can take the *maling*'s hat; and where there are not enough seats available, the *maling* will stand and offer the chair to his *ngala*. The *ngala-maling* relationship is also the basis for labor recruitment, financial assistance, and a general support network. During disputes, the relationship can be evoked as a way to play down the seriousness of the matter, as can be seen in a palaver presented in Chapter 5. In the transcript, Muwulu was speaking and was interrupted by Kokulah. Muwulu threatened his interrupter. The latter then used his *maling* status to institute a repair. Thus, the mutual recognition of this relationship is significant to virtually every aspect of life, from the most formal rituals to frivolous interaction.

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3. To 'reach a matter' means formally to ask or inform someone that he or she is involved in the discussion or situation.

4. See Gibb's film *The Cows of Dolo Ken Paye* (1970), in which a cow's tail was cut off because of a farmer's anger at a chief. By cutting the tail off the cow, the animal could not be used in sacrifice, and thus its value was greatly diminished. When a cow is sacrificed, the *maling* receives the tail from the *ngala* and then uses it as a symbol of authority during palavers and family discussions.

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